

Grading Input Checklist

A practical checklist of the information that helps support stronger and more reliable job evaluation decisions.

Introduction

Strong job evaluation decisions depend on the quality of the inputs used to evaluate the role. That does not mean an organisation needs perfect documentation before evaluation can begin. But it does mean that the information available should be good enough to allow evaluators to understand:

- what the role is designed to do
- how it fits into the structure
- what level of knowledge, accountability, and influence it carries
- how it compares with other roles in the organisation

One of the biggest weaknesses in traditional job evaluation is over-reliance on indirect or incomplete information. Engage is designed to reduce that risk by combining structured evaluation logic with direct role knowledge and organisational context. This checklist is intended to help organisations review whether they have the right information available before evaluating or re-evaluating a role.

1 Role Information Quality

Use the questions below to assess whether the role information is strong enough to support evaluation.

1.1 Role purpose

- ☐ Is there a clear statement of the main purpose of the role?
- ☐ Does the role purpose describe why the role exists, rather than just listing tasks?
- ☐ Is the purpose written in a way that reflects the current role, not an old or idealised version?

1.2 Key outputs and accountabilities

- ☐ Are the main outputs of the role clearly described?
- ☐ Is it clear what the role is accountable for delivering?
- ☐ Are accountabilities expressed as ongoing responsibilities rather than occasional tasks?
- ☐ Is the distinction clear between responsibility for delivery and support to others?

1.3 Nature of the role

- ☐ Is it clear whether the role is primarily technical, managerial, sales-oriented, operational, or mixed?

- ☐ Does the available information reflect the real nature of the work?
- ☐ Does the role appear to have changed materially since it was last described?

1.4 Level of certainty

- ☐ Are evaluators confident that the information reflects the role as it currently operates?
- ☐ Are there obvious gaps, contradictions, or outdated sections?
- ☐ If the role is in flux, is there enough certainty to evaluate the current state rather than an intended future state?

2 Reporting and Structural Context

A role cannot be evaluated well in isolation. Its place in the organisation matters.

2.1 Reporting lines

- ☐ Is the role's reporting line clearly known?
- ☐ Is it clear who the role reports to and at what level?
- ☐ Is it clear whether that reporting line is operational, functional, or both?

2.2 Staff reporting

- ☐ Is it clear whether the role has direct and/or indirect reports?
- ☐ Is the number of staff reporting known and credible?
- ☐ Is there clarity on whether contractors or temporary staff should be included?

2.3 Organisational location

- ☐ Is the role clearly placed within the current organisational structure?
- ☐ Is the function, department, or business area clearly understood?
- ☐ Is there an approved organisation chart available?

2.4 Structural context

- ☐ Is it clear what level of the organisation the role operates at?
- ☐ Is there enough information to understand whether the role sits at function, major job area, job area, or work-routine level where applicable?
- ☐ Is the role's structural importance to the business understood?

3 Job Description Usefulness

Job descriptions can be useful — but they should not be treated as the only source of truth. Engage is clear that role descriptions are helpful as a reference, but not critical, and that solid knowledge of the role is needed even where job descriptions are incomplete or absent.

3.1 Quality of the document

- ☐ Is there a current job description available?
- ☐ Is it written clearly and in a format the organisation recognises?
- ☐ Has it been reviewed and signed off where required?

3.2 Relevance of the content

- ☐ Does the job description reflect the role as it is currently performed?
- ☐ Are there signs that the role has evolved beyond the document?
- ☐ Does the description focus on meaningful role outputs and requirements, rather than generic wording?

3.3 Practical value for grading

- ☐ Does the document help evaluators understand the knowledge, accountability, and scope of the role?
- ☐ Does it clarify reporting relationships and core role purpose?
- ☐ Does it provide a credible basis for discussion, even if clarification may still be needed?

3.4 Warning signs

Be cautious if the job description:

- ☐ is highly generic
- ☐ is clearly outdated
- ☐ mixes current reality with future ambition
- ☐ overstates or understates role complexity
- ☐ focuses heavily on tasks but not accountabilities

4 Additional Evidence That May Be Needed

Where documentation alone is not enough, other forms of evidence may be needed to support a stronger decision.

4.1 Direct role knowledge

- ☐ Is someone with direct knowledge of the role available to clarify questions?
- ☐ Can the line manager explain the role's outputs, complexity, and reporting relationships?
- ☐ Can the incumbent or subject matter expert provide input where needed?

4.2 Organisational data

- ☐ Is there access to organisational charts, business-unit information, or function structures?
- ☐ Is there enough data to understand the size, span, or context of the role?
- ☐ Where relevant, is information available on site control, staff numbers, or business scale?

4.3 Comparative context

- ☐ Is the role being evaluated in relation to surrounding or comparable roles?
- ☐ Is there enough information to support sense-checking against similar roles?
- ☐ Is there clarity on what makes this role bigger, smaller, or different from nearby roles?

4.4 Clarification questions

Before final evaluation, ask:

- ☐ What level of knowledge is genuinely required to perform this role effectively?
- ☐ What decisions does this role actually make?

- ☐ Who does this role influence?
- ☐ What is the real scale of control and accountability?
- ☐ What level of impact does the role have on the business?

5 Role vs Person Discipline Check

A critical part of grading quality is ensuring the evaluation remains focused on the role. Use this section to test whether people issues are distorting the inputs.

5.1 Exclude person-related factors

Confirm that the following are *not* shaping the evaluation:

- ☐ the current employee's performance
- ☐ personal attributes or style
- ☐ tenure in the role
- ☐ scarcity of skills in the market
- ☐ a desire to retain the incumbent
- ☐ hoped-for future expansion of the role

5.2 Focus on the role itself

Check that the evaluation is based on:

- ☐ the work the role is required to do
- ☐ the level of knowledge needed
- ☐ the actual organisational accountabilities
- ☐ the true structural and business context
- ☐ the current role, not future ambition

The methodology is clear: evaluate the role, not the person.

6 Readiness for Evaluation

The role is likely ready if:

- ☐ there is a clear role purpose
- ☐ outputs and accountabilities are sufficiently understood
- ☐ reporting relationships are known
- ☐ organisational context is available
- ☐ evaluators can access direct role knowledge where needed
- ☐ there is enough evidence to make structured judgments confidently

The role may not yet be ready if:

- ☐ the information is clearly outdated or contradictory
- ☐ the role is still being designed

- ☐ the structure is not yet agreed
- ☐ evaluators cannot access anyone with reliable role knowledge
- ☐ the discussion is being driven mainly by pay pressure, retention, or person-related factors

QUICK GRADING INPUT SUMMARY

Before a role is evaluated, ask — **do we understand:**

- why the role exists?
- what it is accountable for?
- where it sits in the structure?
- what level of knowledge and judgment it requires?
- what level of control, influence, and impact it has?

And do we have:

- enough current information?
- enough structural context?
- access to direct role knowledge?
- enough evidence to evaluate the role, not the person?

If the answer is yes, the role is likely ready for evaluation. If not, further clarification should happen before grading takes place.

FINAL NOTE

A strong grading outcome does not depend on perfect paperwork. It depends on having good enough information, direct knowledge where needed, and a disciplined evaluation process. That is what makes job evaluation more credible, transparent, and sustainable over time.

Get the inputs right before you grade

Book a working session and we'll help you assess role readiness and evaluate a sample of your roles live.

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Engage Job Evaluation is a methodology of Africa People Advisory Group (APAG). · engage.africapeopleadvisory.com